



AN INSTITUTION IN HIMSELF Narayanan Vaghul's sense of humour, storytelling ability, and spiritual insights made him a unique leader

was raised through a 1989 public offering and a 1994 \$200 million convertible bond offering. In 1988-89, Vaghul initiated a project to obtain a Moody's rating, led by Nachiket Mor.

Ahead of his time, Vaghul championed venture capital for start-ups and small companies needing risk capital, establishing the over-the-

counter (OTC) exchange and co-promoting the National Stock Exchange (NSE).

Vaghul instituted systematic hiring from IIMs, bringing in leaders like Nachiket Mor and Madhabi Puri Buch.

He also championed gender diversity, leading to the emergence of

senior women leaders at ICICI—including Shikha (Sharma, who joined ICICI in 1980 and left in 2009 as MD & CEO of ICICI Pru Life), Renuka (Ramnath, who became MD & CEO of ICICI Ventures), and Lalita (D. Gupte, Joint MD till October 31, 2006).

In 1996, as he turned 60, he identified Kamath as his successor, persuading him to return from ADB. The 2001 merger of ICICI and ICICI Bank, a significant milestone, saw Vaghul play a crucial role despite regulatory challenges.

Even after my retirement, I remained connected with Vaghul. At

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his book release in Mumbai, he invited me to join the Krea University governing council, which he chaired. Our association continued beyond our time at ICICI.

Vaghul's sense of humour, storytelling ability, and spiritual insights made him a unique leader. His sessions on the relevance of *Bhagavad Gita*, even in the current corporate life, inspired young minds.

Vaghul was a versatile man, a mentor, and a visionary leader. His passing is a profound loss. **BT**

As told to Anand Adhikari. The author is Former Chair, J.P. Morgan, South & Southeast Asia and Former Joint MD, ICICI Bank. Views are personal